

The Renaissance in Italy

That Italy should be the crucible of Renaissance architecture is no surprise: it was a short, if momentous leap for it to forsake Gothic and revive the ideals of ancient Rome, whose ruins were so close at hand. The Italian architects of the era felt a close affinity with art (many were, in fact, artists), and their vision focused more on form than on structure.

In 1452, architect and humanist Leon Battista Alberti published *De Re Aedificatoria* (*On the Art of Building*), after studying ancient Rome. Following *De Architectura* (c.15 BCE) by Vitruvius, Alberti's treatise covered history, town planning, engineering, sacred geometry, humanism and philosophies of beauty. The book was a revelation, setting out in mathematical detail the key elements of architecture – square, cube, circle and sphere – and ideal proportions. And as rich patrons in the city states vied to outdo each other with opulent palaces, it became part of an architect's essential training to study the relics of Rome, especially the Colosseum and the Pantheon.



Facade of Santa Maria Novella, Florence, by Alberti, 1456–70